

TO THE STUDENT WHO IS TIRED OF BEING STRONG

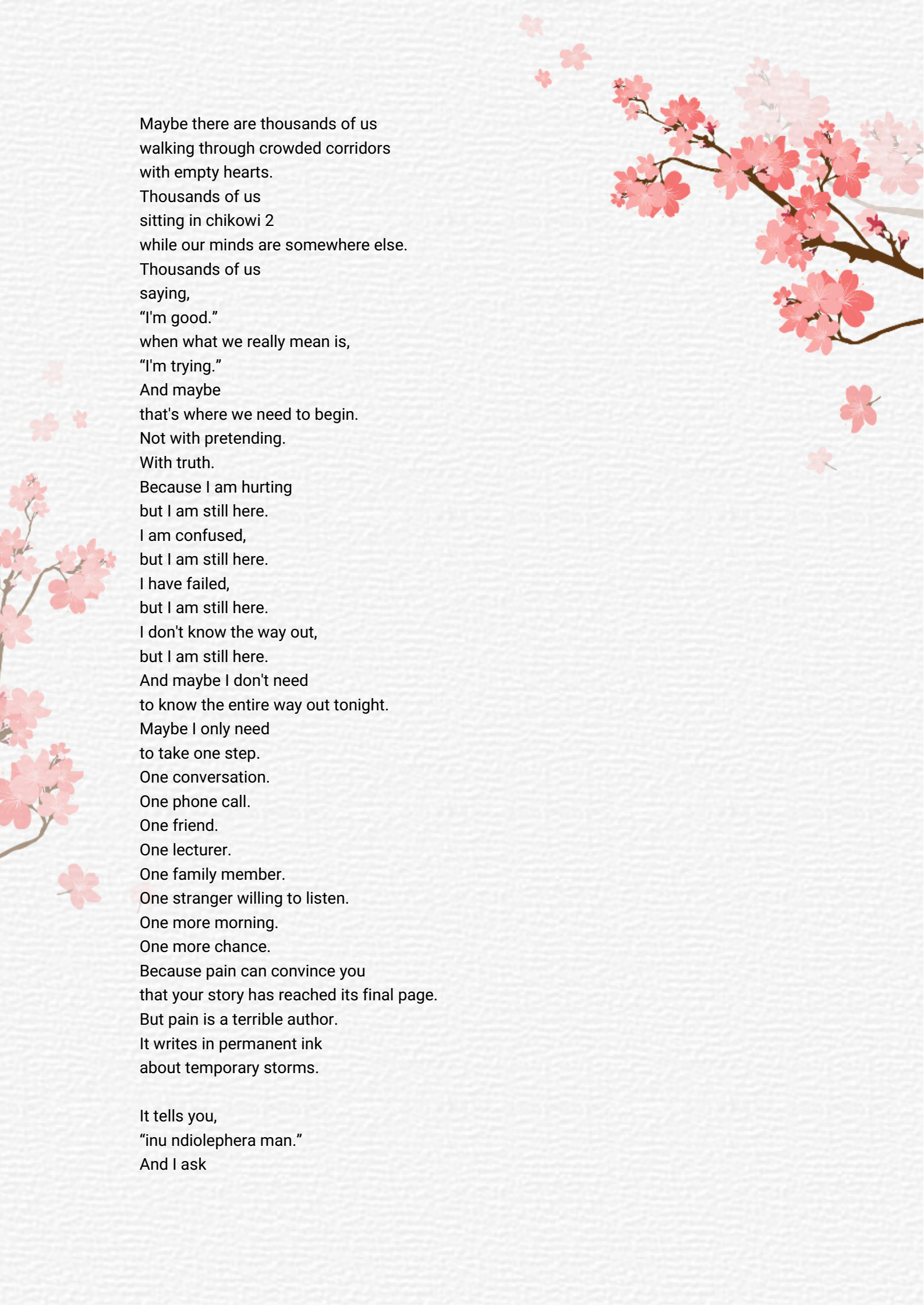
BY ARSLY MWAMWAYA

I Don't Have to Pretend
I don't have to pretend I'm okay.
I can say
I'm tired.
I can say
I'm scared.
I can say
I don't know how I'm going to pay these fees,
I don't know how I'm going to pass this course,
I don't know what tomorrow is carrying,
and honestly,

I don't know if I can carry myself anymore.
I can say it.
Because pretending
has never paid a debt,
never passed an examination,
never healed a broken heart,
never put food on an empty table.
So no,
I won't smile just because everyone expects me to.

Some nights,
the university becomes more than classrooms.
It becomes pressure.
Deadlines breathing down my neck,
results staring back at me,
fees standing between me and graduation,
a relationship falling apart,
a family expecting greatness
when I can barely find strength to wake up.

And then I look around.
Everyone seems fine.
Everyone is posting.
Everyone is laughing.
Everyone is moving forward.
So I ask myself,
"Why am I the only one falling behind?"
But maybe,
maybe I'm not.

The page is decorated with delicate cherry blossom branches. In the top right corner, a branch with many pink blossoms extends across the top. In the bottom left corner, another branch with pink blossoms is visible. Scattered individual pink blossoms are also present in the top left and bottom right areas.

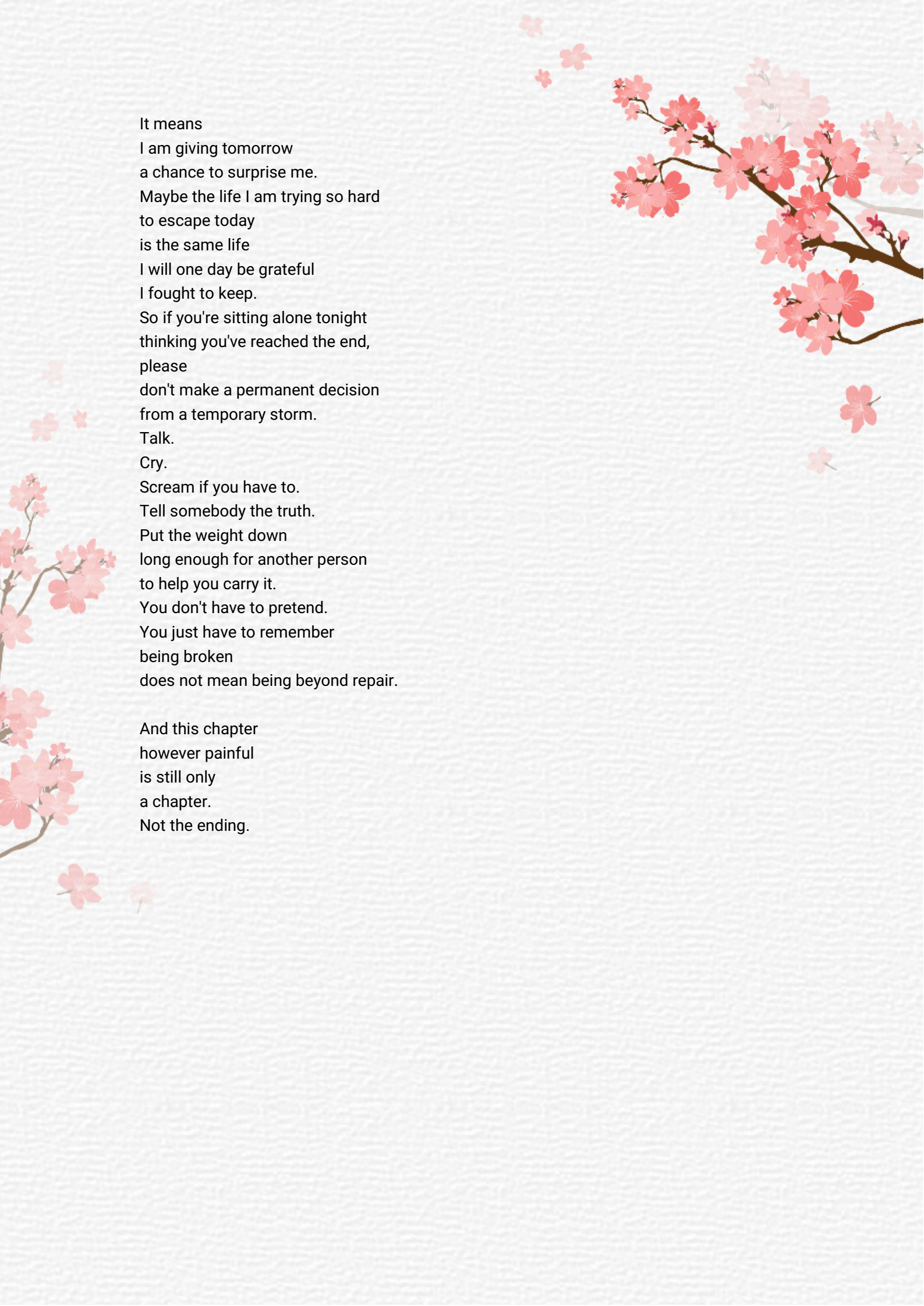
Maybe there are thousands of us
walking through crowded corridors
with empty hearts.
Thousands of us
sitting in chikowi 2
while our minds are somewhere else.
Thousands of us
saying,
"I'm good."
when what we really mean is,
"I'm trying."
And maybe
that's where we need to begin.
Not with pretending.
With truth.
Because I am hurting
but I am still here.
I am confused,
but I am still here.
I have failed,
but I am still here.
I don't know the way out,
but I am still here.
And maybe I don't need
to know the entire way out tonight.
Maybe I only need
to take one step.
One conversation.
One phone call.
One friend.
One lecturer.
One family member.
One stranger willing to listen.
One more morning.
One more chance.
Because pain can convince you
that your story has reached its final page.
But pain is a terrible author.
It writes in permanent ink
about temporary storms.

It tells you,
"inu ndiolephera man."
And I ask



Am I?
It says,
"There is nothing left."
And I ask,
Are you certain?
It says,
"No one will miss you."
And I answer
You don't get to decide that.
It says,
"Your failure is who you are."
And I say,
No.
I failed.
I am not failure.
I am hurting.
I am not pain.
I am struggling.
I am not defeated.

I may not know
what tomorrow looks like,
but I refuse
to let tonight
make the decision
for every tomorrow I haven't seen.
So no,
I don't have to pretend I'm good.
I don't have to wear happiness
like a uniform.
I don't have to laugh
when I want to cry.
I don't have to hide
behind "ndilibhobho man."
I can be honest.
I can break.
I can cry.
I can ask for help.
I can admit,
"I don't know what to do."
And still
choose to stay.
Because staying
doesn't mean everything is suddenly okay.



It means
I am giving tomorrow
a chance to surprise me.
Maybe the life I am trying so hard
to escape today
is the same life
I will one day be grateful
I fought to keep.
So if you're sitting alone tonight
thinking you've reached the end,
please
don't make a permanent decision
from a temporary storm.
Talk.
Cry.
Scream if you have to.
Tell somebody the truth.
Put the weight down
long enough for another person
to help you carry it.
You don't have to pretend.
You just have to remember
being broken
does not mean being beyond repair.

And this chapter
however painful
is still only
a chapter.
Not the ending.